

Chris Lam

Product Design Engineer for AI-native products

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Remote US from Honolulu, HI · Works West Coast hours · Quarterly Bay Area and Seattle travel

SUMMARY

Product design engineer with 14 years shipping healthcare, creative, developer, and consumer software. Built my career in product design, including early roles at Clover Health, GoodRx, Pathstream, and StartPlaying, then deliberately deepened into production engineering. Today I own products end to end: research, interaction design, design systems, React/TypeScript/Python implementation, agent architecture, evals, and production verification. Recent work includes a voice-AI system with deterministic safety controls and collaborative game-development tooling with a custom real-time engine. Seeking senior or lead IC design-engineering roles on AI-native teams.

EXPERIENCE

Co-Founder & CPTO · y30

Mar 2026 to Aug 2026 · Operated as founding CPTO through Aug 2026; advising since. Voice AI for older adults and their care teams.

- Built an FSM safety engine where crisis paths are deterministic code, not prompt instructions, a hard state the model cannot override.
- Architected a streaming speech-to-text to LLM to text-to-speech pipeline (multi-provider, deep fallback) fronted by a deterministic state machine.
- Scoped the language model to phrasing and warmth while conversation flow runs as a deterministic state machine; about half of routing decisions resolve with no model call.
- Built the first version in TypeScript, then deliberately rewrote it in Python to fit the real-time voice framework, carrying the state-machine architecture and safety model across the rewrite.
- Designed elder-first voice UX: no app, no screen, no login, just a phone call.

Entrepreneur in Residence · Blue Startups

Jul 2024 to Nov 2024 · Concurrent with PlaySesh, during a pivot. Conducted design and product audits for 10 early-stage startups in cohort 16. Advised on product strategy, MVP scope, and design-to-engineering handoffs.

Co-Founder & CEO · PlaySesh

Jan 2024 to Mar 2026 · Collaborative game development tools for indie developers, built inside Discord. Started while finishing at Modus Create.

- Started 0 to 1 solo, then recruited a co-founder and founding engineer; remained CEO, setting company and product direction, owning product and design, and contributing hands-on testing and implementation.
- Shipped Whiteboard by PlaySesh inside Discord with TLDraw, Cloudflare Durable Objects, and R2; active development paused in March 2026 and the Discord product remains live.
- Grew organically to over 6,200 authorized Discord accounts, 138 server installs, and 67 individual-user installs; peaked at 1,043 monthly active users (January 2026). Discord counts are approximate, as of August 1, 2026.
- Pivoted from social gaming to game dev tooling based on user behavior signal.

Software Engineer · Modus Create

Jun 2023 to Feb 2024 · Designed and implemented cross-app dark mode and visual consistency for Jira and Confluence Cloud products serving a 500K+ installed/reachable user base. Shipped through PR review, automated tests, visual QA, and the team's existing CI/CD; authored README and setup documentation.

Founding Product Designer · StartPlaying

Jul 2022 to Jan 2023 · First designer at a YC W20, a16z-backed seed-stage TTRPG marketplace. Shipped Stripe-based marketplace money flows, refunds, and player-debt reconciliation, enabling correct and timely GM payouts and traceable accounting. Completed a GM onboarding redesign that was not launched.

Lead Product Designer · doc.ai (acquired by Sharecare)

Feb 2021 to Oct 2021 · Hired by doc.ai; exited under Sharecare paperwork after the acquisition. Became sole design owner for Omix, consolidating fragmented clinical-study workflows into a working engineering build validated with researchers; canceled before public launch after the acquisition.

Senior Product Design Manager · Pathstream

Jun 2019 to Nov 2020 · Operated as lead designer. First design hire at a career-development and LMS platform.

- Redesigned the core lesson experience on a live platform, mid-cohort, without forcing a rewrite of 60-80 hours of existing course content.
- Designed the platform's shared interface system with engineer Matt Clinton, who implemented it in React with Storybook and Chromatic on top of Ant Design.
- Ran the research that set the direction: a 26-screen product audit in week three, three rounds of usability testing, five course-author co-design sessions, and instructor interviews.
- Audited the interface library and found the drift: sixteen colors where four grays were all labeled Text, two different values both called Primary Button, body copy at four sizes, and a 10.3px type size shipping to adult learners.

Lead Product Designer · Iodine (acquired by GoodRx)

Apr 2017 to Oct 2018 · First full-time designer, on GoodRx's special research and experimentation team. Title was self-assigned. A contractor preceded him and never converted. GoodRx later IPO'd (NASDAQ: GDRX).

- Redesigned the coupon redemption flow; conversion rate 2% to 5%.
- Ran a series of conversion projects across the drug pages: 10% lift on mobile, 25% on desktop.
- Contributed to GoodRx Research data visualizations referenced in the New York Times and on Good Morning America / ABC News.
- Iodine.com won the Webby for Best Health Website (2018). I was the product's designer.
- Built 50-state prescription-price fact sheets with GoodRx co-CEO Doug Hirsch, used in advocacy around S.2554 and S.2553 on drug price transparency.

Designer · Clover Health

Jul 2015 to Sep 2016 · Second designer, joined when it was about 30 people and founder-funded, months before the Series A. The title was deliberately broad. Operated as a product design lead. Clover later IPO'd (NYSE: CLOV).

- Helped build the design function as the second designer: established how design, engineering, and product worked together, sat in product development, and co-wrote PRDs with the product manager.
- Redesigned the nurse practitioner home-visit iPad web app end to end through contextual shadowing. about 7-8x ROI on the increase in revenue; saved ~2 hours per nurse per day.
- Led cross-functional alignment across design, engineering, product, data science, and medical.

Product Designer · TaskRabbit

May 2014 to Mar 2015 · Worked on the 2014 rebrand; TaskRabbit later acquired by IKEA (2017).

- Hired by founder and CEO Leah Busque onto a new design team as TaskRabbit moved from bidding to direct hire. Owned the Tasker side of the experience outright and contributed to the consumer side.
- Tasker NPS recovered from about -5 in mid-2014 to the mid-50s; Client NPS to the high-40s.
- Led the mobile design system after the 2014 rebrand: one type scale, an icon set specified at six sizes, four named colour families each with a ten-step scale, and component specs through to empty states. Picked it up because nobody owned it and the design team had drifted, with each designer owning different pieces.

User Experience Designer · Amazon

Apr 2012 to Sep 2013

- Prototyped the buy-and-gift Prime flow, projected to drive 1M+ new subscribers.
- Partnered with Samsung on the Amazon Prime Music app for the Samsung Shape wireless speaker.

EDUCATION

MS, Human-Centered Design & Engineering · University of Washington · 2012

BS, Informatics, Human-Computer Interaction · University of Washington · 2010

SKILLS

Product & Design: Product design (0 to 1) · Interaction design · Design systems · Design tokens · Storybook & Chromatic · UX research · Prototyping · Information architecture · WCAG accessibility · Product strategy · Elder-care UX · Figma · Sketch · Adobe Photoshop/Illustrator

Production Engineering: React · TypeScript · Python · Next.js · HTML/CSS · Vanilla JS · Supabase · Firebase · PostgreSQL · Cloudflare Workers · Docker · CI/CD · Test-driven development · Real-time systems · Telemetry & instrumentation

AI-Native Systems: Agent UX · LLM orchestration · Multi-agent orchestration · Agentic systems · Evals & evaluation UX · Guardrails & deterministic safety control · FSM/LLM safety · Prompt & system-instruction design · Provenance & human-AI oversight · Agent frameworks · MCP · LiveKit · Real-time STT/TTS · Voice AI · Claude Code · Cursor · GitHub Copilot · Codex · Superset · OpenRouter · Perplexity · Multi-model adversarial review